

The Confederate war

In many ways, Southerners had suffered more than Northerners. An estimated 80 percent of military-aged men entered service and nearly one-third of those who fought were killed. Most of the fighting took place in the South with dramatic impact. Armies swept over the countryside, consuming food and wood at the expense of local inhabitants, with perhaps 40 percent of Southern livestock taken for military purposes. An unknown number of civilians died and hundreds of thousands of white and Black citizens became refugees. Confederates returned to a devastated South.

War destroyed two-thirds of the wealth of the South, most of all in the value of enslaved people. The Southern economy became a shambles. Reliance on printed currency led to astronomical inflation (over 9,000 percent) and worthless Confederate money. Southern banks held insufficient capital for rebuilding infrastructure. And the Confederate government had increasingly seized much-needed supplies from its people in exchange for worthless currency.